

Gallantry Award Winner has instilled the values of courage, bravery and selflessness in me. I will inculcate them in daily life by...

Inspired by the true story of Subedar and Honorary Captain Karam Singh PVC, MM

*The bus left me standing at the door of Balwinder Singh's home. As it vroomed off into the distance, I looked around myself. The grass had grown wild, and the pavement looked shabby. The house itself, as well as the surrounding cottages, looked more lifeless than a deserted amusement park. The doors and the windows were latched, and I might have believed that there was no one at home if I had not known the recent tragedy that had struck this small village in the outskirts of Punjab. With a heavy heart, I knocked on the door. A few moments of silence passed, then a few noises of movement inside the house, and then finally I found myself facing Ballu's mother. I had been bracing myself for this moment for weeks, running over all the things I would say in my head, over and over again. Yet still, somehow, when I was finally here, my lips betrayed me and my willpower shattered. Somehow, singlehandedly tackling a gang of bloodthirsty terrorists seemed much easier than this. So, I just looked at her miserable face. I looked over her shoulder at the two tiny innocent girls, who were admiring the newly hung portrait of their father on the wall, adorned with a garland of marigolds, not realizing what it meant. "Baba looks good in that picture", they said, pointing. "Baba..."*

"Baba! In what world have you been?" I hear my son saying and, with a jolt, return to present. Here he is, sitting beside me, doing his math problems. "You finish your homework, *puttar*. I am going for a walk.", I say.

I walk out of the study room, stand at the edge of the field and watch the children of the village play. I still recall the day I set up this school in our village. It had started out humbly with me giving Punjabi lessons to Ballu's daughters and a few other children of the neighbourhood. The school has developed since then. We now have educated teachers that teach Punjabi, Math, Science, History and dance. A building has been constructed around the tree under which I initially started out the school. Ballu's daughters are now among the senior students. I observe them teaching the younger ones how to properly make a tackle in kabaddi.

*"They are coming. There is just the four of us and they are innumerable. What do we do?", cried Sundar. I looked over to the approaching enemy troop and quickly weighed our chances. Hoshiyar Singh and Karamchand were seriously injured, we were low on ammunition and there was little chance of getting more supplies from the main company, because the enemy*

*was raining shells on us. We were about to die, and at that moment, strangely, I experienced a surge of pride. We were about to lay our lives for our nation, about to be immortalized on this holy land. "Get up warrior!", I yelled. I pulled out a grenade from my backpack, bit off the pin, and threw it straight at the enemy, crying the war-cry of the Tenth Guru, "Jo bole so nihal! Sat sri akaal!" Another grenade followed suit, obliterating large chunks of the troop, but I did not take much time to realize that we stood no chance against their sheer numbers. I looked over at Hoshiyar's and Karam's bloodied uniforms, Sundar's depleted face and quickly decided that we had no choice but to return to camp. Sundar and I grabbed Hoshiyar and Karam, and dragging them, headed straight into the onslaught of shells.*

I find that my feet have carried me across the field, over to the road. I continue walking down the road.

*There was no rest since 6 a.m. All my men were drained and our resources were depleting. The enemy had attacked the main camp itself. Two of the enemy troop's men made it to the final few yards from our camp, and brandished their rifles. I saw them approach and realized that they were too close to shoot. Making up my mind on the spot, I climbed up, pulled out my bayonet and stabbed one of them repeatedly right in the stomach. A gush of blood spurted out, he groaned in horror and pain, until he fell down lifeless. The other faltered, but I inflicted the same treatment on him without hesitation. Their convulsed faces as I stabbed them have haunted me ever since.*

"AHHH! SOMEONE SAVE MY KID!"

The woman's scream brings me back to the present. Her toddler has crawled his way onto the road, on which a speeding truck is coming his way. The truck driver gets frightened on seeing the child, and tries to swerve out the way, but the truck is too close to the baby. All thought ceases, all senses rouse. For a moment, it seems that time itself stops, and I make the dive.

*Ballu unleashed another fierce volley of bullets upon the enemy. We were close to the end. The enemy was retreating. We would make it alive after all. And then, I thought with a sigh of relief, that I could go back with Ballu to our home village. Then maybe Ballu's mother would make me that sarson ka saag that I so love. I could almost taste it right there, and smacked my lips. Mmmm! Ballu – my best friend, my brother-in-arms.*

*And that's when it happened. I saw it coming. I dived to push him out of the way. But...*

I grab hold of the baby and jump out of the way of the truck just in the nick of the time. The baby is unscathed. I see the baby's mother sprint over to me, I see her shaking hands with me and thanking me profusely, I see the other people on the street gather round me to praise me.

“Oh kind sir! How can I ever repay you?”

“There will be no need for that ma'am. Just keep an eye on your son in the future. For the loss of a child is unbearable.”, I say, as a tear trickles down my cheek.

And in that instant, when I had saved the life of a mother's child, I felt more rewarded than being awarded the highest gallantry award of the country.

- Manan Garg

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